

MATH 345 Skeleton Notes

Unit 1: Vectors, matrices, and linear maps

Section 1.2: Matrices

© 2024–2026 Jacob Denson, Kaitlyn Phillipson, Sebastien Roch. Except where otherwise noted, this work is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-ShareAlike 4.0 International License.

Matrices can be viewed in two complementary ways: as arrays of data and as functions acting on vectors. We begin with basic matrix arithmetic, then use matrix-vector multiplication to describe linear maps.

Matrices as arrays of numbers

Definition: Matrices

An $m \times n$ matrix A is a rectangular array of $m \cdot n$ real numbers arranged in m

(horizontal) rows and n

(vertical) columns :

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} a_{11} & a_{12} & \cdots & a_{1n} \\ a_{21} & a_{22} & \cdots & a_{2n} \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ a_{m1} & a_{m2} & \cdots & a_{mn} \end{bmatrix}$$

The i -th row of A is

$$[a_{i1} \ a_{i2} \ \cdots \ a_{in}] ,$$

and the

j -th column of A is

$$\begin{bmatrix} a_{1j} \\ a_{2j} \\ \vdots \\ a_{mj} \end{bmatrix}.$$

The number a_{ij} , which is in the i -th row and j -th column of A , is the

(i, j) -entry

of A , and we often write $A = [a_{ij}]$. We say A is an ”

m by n

” matrix.

Activity

Consider the matrix

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 5 & -8 & -13 \end{bmatrix}$$

A is a 2×3 matrix. Compute the following:

$$a_{11}$$

Activity

Consider the matrix

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 5 & -8 & -13 \end{bmatrix}$$

A is a 2×3 matrix. Compute the following:

$$a_{12}$$

Activity

Consider the matrix

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 5 & -8 & -13 \end{bmatrix}$$

A is a 2×3 matrix. Compute the following:

a_{21}

Activity

Consider the matrix

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 5 & -8 & -13 \end{bmatrix}$$

A is a 2×3 matrix. Compute the following:

a_{23}

Activity

Consider the matrix

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 5 & -8 & -13 \end{bmatrix}$$

Activity (continued)

A is a 2×3 matrix. Compute the following:

$$a_{32}$$

An important application of matrices (but far from the only one!) is to record data. The following table gives a few examples.

- **Object:** Monochrome image
Meaning of an entry: X_{ij} is the pixel value in row i and column j .
- **Object:** Rainfall data
Meaning of an entry: A_{ij} is the rainfall at location j on day i .
- **Object:** Asset returns
Meaning of an entry: R_{ij} is the return of asset i in period j .
- **Object:** Feature matrix
Meaning of an entry: X_{ij} is the value of feature j for entity i .

Operations on matrices

Definition: Equality of matrices

Two matrices A and B are equal if they have the same size and all the corresponding entries are equal.

Activity

Suppose

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & y \\ 4 & -7 \end{bmatrix} \quad \text{and} \quad B = \begin{bmatrix} 6 + x & -2 \\ 4 & -7 \end{bmatrix}$$

and $A = B$. Find x and y .

Definition: Sums of matrices

If $A = [a_{ij}]$ and $B = [b_{ij}]$ are both $m \times n$ matrices, then their $A + B$ is the matrix $C = [c_{ij}]$ where $c_{ij} = a_{ij} + b_{ij}$.

sum

Activity

For the matrices

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 5 & -8 & -13 \end{bmatrix} \quad \text{and} \quad B = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 2 & 1 \\ 1 & 3 & -4 \end{bmatrix}$$

calculate $A + B$.

Warning

For $A + B$ to be defined, A and B must be the same size. From now on, if we write $A + B$, assume that this is the case.

Definition: Scalar multiples of matrices

If $A = [a_{ij}]$ is an $m \times n$ matrix and r is a real number, then the

scalar multiple

of A by r , written rA , is the $m \times n$ matrix

$C = [c_{ij}]$, where $c_{ij} = ra_{ij}$, that is, C is the matrix obtained by multiplying every entry of A by r .

Activity

For A as in the activity, calculate $-2A$.

Note

The $m \times n$ matrix with zeros in every entry is called the

zero matrix

and is denoted by O . For every $m \times n$ matrix A ,

we have $A + O = A$. The **negative** of A is the matrix $-A = (-1)A$, and $A + (-A) = O$.

Theorem

Let A , B , and C be $m \times n$ matrices.

1. $A + B = B + A$, i.e., matrix addition is

commutative.

2. $A + (B + C) = (A + B) + C$, i.e., matrix addition is

associative.

3. Let r and s be real numbers. Then:

(a) $r(sA) = (rs)A$.

(b) $(r + s)A = rA + sA$.

$$(c) \ r(A + B) = rA + rB.$$

Why is this true?

We prove Property 1 only, i.e., the commutativity of addition. Let $A = [a_{ij}]$ and $B = [b_{ij}]$. Then:

$$\begin{aligned} A + B &= [a_{ij} + b_{ij}] \\ &= [b_{ij} + a_{ij}] && \text{(since real numbers are commutative)} \\ &= B + A \end{aligned}$$

Definition

If $A = [a_{ij}]$ is an $m \times n$ matrix, then the transpose of A , denoted $A^T = [a_{ij}^T]$, is the $n \times m$ matrix defined by

$$a_{ij}^T = a_{ji}$$

In other words, the transpose of A is obtained by *interchanging* the rows and the columns of A .

Activity

Compute the transpose for each of the given matrices:

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & 3 \\ 5 & -8 & -13 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Activity

Compute the transpose for each of the given matrices:

$$B = \begin{bmatrix} 5 & 2 & 3 \\ 6 & 2 & 3 \\ -1 & -2 & 3 \end{bmatrix}$$

Activity

Compute the transpose for each of the given matrices:

$$C = \begin{bmatrix} 10 \\ 20 \\ 30 \end{bmatrix}.$$

Note

Observe from the previous activity that, when transposed, a column vector becomes a row vector. And vice versa.

Definition: Main diagonal

If $A = [a_{ij}]$ is an $m \times n$ matrix, the elements $a_{11}, a_{22}, a_{33}, \dots$ are called the **main diagonal** of A . A matrix A is called **diagonal** if its only nonzero entries occur on its main diagonal.

Below are four matrices of various dimensions, with the main diagonal written in bold font.

$$\begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{a}_{11} & a_{12} & a_{13} \\ a_{21} & \mathbf{a}_{22} & a_{23} \\ a_{31} & a_{32} & \mathbf{a}_{33} \end{bmatrix}$$

$$\begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{a}_{11} & a_{12} \\ a_{21} & \mathbf{a}_{22} \\ a_{31} & a_{32} \end{bmatrix}$$

$$\begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{a}_{11} & a_{12} & a_{13} \\ a_{21} & \mathbf{a}_{22} & a_{23} \end{bmatrix}$$

$$\begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{a}_{11} \\ a_{21} \end{bmatrix}$$

Forming the transpose of a matrix A can be viewed as *flipping* A about its main diagonal.

Theorem

If r is a scalar and A and B are matrices of the appropriate sizes, then:

1. $(A^T)^T = A$.
2. $(A + B)^T = A^T + B^T$.
3. $(rA)^T = rA^T$.

Why is this true?

Proof of property 2:

Let $A = [a_{ij}]$ and $B = [b_{ij}]$. Then $A + B = [c_{ij}]$ where $c_{ij} = a_{ij} + b_{ij}$.

Then

$$\begin{aligned}
(A + B)^T &= [c_{ij}^T] \\
&= [c_{ji}] && \text{By definition of transpose} \\
&= [a_{ji} + b_{ji}] && \text{Since } c_{ij} = a_{ij} + b_{ij} \\
&= [a_{ji}] + [b_{ji}] && \text{By definition of matrix addition} \\
&= [a_{ij}^T] + [b_{ij}^T] && \text{By definition of transpose} \\
&= A^T + B^T
\end{aligned}$$

Therefore, $(A + B)^T = A^T + B^T$.

Definition: Symmetric matrices

A matrix A with real entries is called **symmetric** if $A^T = A$.

Warning

The previous definition only makes sense if the matrix A is

square, i.e., if it has the same number of rows and columns.

Activity

Determine whether each of the following matrices is symmetric or not symmetric:

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 2 & -3 \\ -2 & 0 & 5 \\ 3 & -5 & 0 \end{bmatrix}$$

Activity

Determine whether each of the following matrices is symmetric or not symmetric:

$$B = \begin{bmatrix} 3 & 5 & 2 \\ 5 & 1 & 4 \\ 2 & 4 & -1 \end{bmatrix}$$

Activity

Determine whether each of the following matrices is symmetric or not symmetric:

$$C = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 2 & -3 \\ -2 & 0 & 5 \\ 3 & 5 & 0 \end{bmatrix}$$

Activity

Determine whether each of the following matrices is symmetric or not symmetric:

$$D = \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{bmatrix}$$

Note: Shape habit

Before adding or transposing matrices, first identify their shapes. A 2×3 matrix has two rows and three columns. Matrix addition requires the same shape, while transposing a 2×3 matrix produces a 3×2 matrix.